of Russian oil supplies to India.

The "shadow fleet" comprises ships that allegedly skirted the price cap on Russian oil exports the G7 had imposed in December 2022. Under this, western shipping and insurance companies were barred from dealing with Russian oil, which cost over $60 a barrel, in order to squeeze the revenues of Russian oil firms.

The curbs on Russia could see Iraq or Saudi Arabia becoming our largest crude suppliers. Of the 158 MT of crude India imported between April and November 2024, 61 MT came from Russia, followed by Iraq (31.7 MT), Saudi Arabia (20 MT) and the UAE (13.3 MT).

OIL SPILL

- **American sanctions on Russian oil could affect supplies to India, and inflate the country's import bill**
- **The refining margins of Indian refining and marketing companies will also take a hit, affecting their profitability**

Indian refining and marketing companies like Reliance Industries, Indian Oil Corporation, Hindustan Petroleum and Bharat Petroleum may see their margins suffer. "Discounted crude has buoyed the margins of refining companies," says Prashant Vasisht, senior VP and co-group head, corporate ratings, ICRA. "Margins are $4-5 per barrel, of which almost 40 per cent is discounted crude." Russian discount on crude is certain to go up, taking cost to sub-$60 a barrel, at least for inferior grades. Others are convinced that Russia will continue to maintain a shadow fleet and find ways to reach its crude to other parts of the world. And the show would go on. ■



PTI

WEST BENGAL/ RG KAR VERDICT

DEBATE OVER QUANTUM OF PUNISHMENT

By Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

The verdict in the RG Kar rape and murder case was delivered on January 20 as additional sessions judge Anirban Das pronounced life imprisonment for the main accused, Sanjay Roy. While his order ruled out capital punishment, the Central Bureau of Investigation and the Bengal government moved the Calcutta High Court, seeking a harsher penalty. After an initial hearing on January 27, the HC reserved its judgment. The victim's grieving parents allege evidence-tampering and misuse of power, but have submitted in the HC that they don't seek Roy's death. The court, while critical of investigative lapses, upheld the prosecution's evidence, which did not align with the more dramatic narratives in the air from the start.

Initially, assumptions of gang rape and a chaotic crime scene dominated public perception, but the investigators—Kolkata Police and the CBI—parsed the postmortem report, CCTV footage, video and photographic evidence and witness testimonies to conclude that the crime was committed by a single individual. Roy was a civic volunteer tasked to look after police personnel and their families and had access to government hospitals. On the night of August 9, 2024, an inebriated Roy chanced upon the sleeping junior doctor, whom he did not know, and com-